GROW FOOD SYSTEM

ACTION KIT

30-Day Food System Action Plan

A day-by-day plan for your first month growing food at home. Know exactly what to do, when to do it, and how to build momentum from day one.

- Week 1: Assess your space and make a plan
- Week 2: Set up and plant your first crops
- Week 3: Tend, learn, and build routine
- Week 4: Sustain, expand, and plan ahead

How to use this plan

This plan gives you one clear task per day for your first 30 days. Each day builds on the last. You do not need to do everything perfectly. You just need to keep moving forward.

BEFORE YOU START

You do not need any equipment, seeds, or experience to begin. Week 1 is entirely about planning. You will not plant anything until you are ready.

The 4-week structure

Week 1 — Assess & Decide

Understand your space, choose what to grow, and make a simple plan. No buying, no planting yet.

Week 2 — Set Up & Plant

Get your materials, prepare your growing area, and put your first plants in.

Week 3 — Tend & Learn

Build a daily routine, observe what is happening, and adjust as needed.

Week 4 — Sustain & Expand

Consolidate what is working, add one more thing, and plan your next season.

Start on any day of the week. If you miss a day, do not restart — just pick up where you left off. If a task does not apply to your situation, skip it and move on. Progress matters more than perfection.

01 Assess & Decide

Days 1–7 · No buying, no planting — just planning

1. **Walk your space**
   Spend 15 minutes outside. Notice where the sun falls, where water collects, where you naturally walk. Take a few photos for reference.

2. **Measure your light**
   Check your growing area at 9am, 12pm, and 3pm. Note which parts get full sun (6+ hours), partial sun (3–6 hours), or shade. This determines what you can grow.

3. **List what you actually eat**
   Write down 10 fruits, vegetables, or herbs you buy regularly. Circle the 3–5 you would most like to grow yourself. This is your starting shortlist.

4. **Match crops to your space**
   Cross-reference your shortlist with your light conditions. Drop anything that needs full sun if you have shade. Keep 2–3 realistic choices.

5. **Choose your growing method**
   Containers, a raised bed, or direct in the ground? Choose based on your space, budget, and how much you want to commit to. Containers are the lowest-risk starting point.

6. **Write your simple plan**
   One sentence: "I am going to grow [2–3 crops] in [containers/bed/ground] in [location]." Write it down. This is your plan.

7. **Make your shopping list**
   List exactly what you need: pots or bed materials, compost, seeds or starter plants, a watering can. Nothing else. Resist the urge to overbuy.

02 Set Up & Plant

Days 8–14 · Get your materials and put plants in

8 **Buy your supplies**
Get everything on your list from Day 7. A garden centre or hardware store is fine. Starter plants are easier than seeds for your first time.

9 **Prepare your growing area**
Set up containers or clear your bed space. Fill with compost. Position everything in the spot you chose on Day 1. Make sure it drains properly.

10 **Plant your first crop**
Start with just one. Plant it properly: right depth, enough space, watered in well. If using seeds, follow the packet spacing and depth instructions exactly.

11 **Plant the rest**
Add your remaining 1–2 crops. Give each enough space. Label everything so you remember what is where.

12 **Water and check**
Water everything thoroughly. Check soil moisture by pressing a finger into the top inch. If it is dry, water. If it is damp, leave it.

13 **Set your watering routine**
Decide when you will water each day. Morning is best. Make it part of an existing habit — before breakfast, after coffee, before work. Consistency matters more than perfection.

14 **Take a photo**
Photograph your setup from the same angle. You will do this again on Day 30 to see how far you have come. Save it somewhere easy to find.

03 Tend & Learn

Days 15–21 · Build routine, observe, adjust

15 **Morning check-in**
Spend 5 minutes looking at your plants. Are leaves wilting, yellowing, or thriving? Touch the soil. This daily observation is how you learn to read your plants.

16 **Check for pests**
Look under leaves and along stems. Aphids, slugs, and caterpillars are the most common early problems. Remove by hand or use a gentle soap spray.

17 **Feed if needed**
Container plants benefit from a liquid feed every 1–2 weeks once growing. A general-purpose organic feed is fine. Ground plants in good compost usually do not need feeding yet.

18 **Thin or support**
If seedlings are crowded, thin them to the recommended spacing. If anything is flopping, add a small stake or support. This prevents problems later.

19 **Pick and use something**
If anything is ready — herbs, salad leaves, even a few small leaves — pick some and use them today. Using what you grew closes the loop and keeps you motivated.

20 **Note what is working**
Write down which plant is doing best, which spot gets the best light, and anything you would do differently next time. This is your growing journal starting.

21 **Rest and observe**
Do nothing except water if needed. Sit near your plants for a few minutes. Most new growers over-tend. Learning when to leave things alone is a real skill.

04 Sustain & Expand

Days 22–30 · Consolidate, add one thing, plan ahead

22 **Review your routine**
Is your watering time working? Are you checking in daily? If something is slipping, adjust the time or method. A system only works if it fits your life.

23 **Succession sow**
Plant a second batch of your fastest crop — salad leaves, radishes, or herbs. This extends your harvest and teaches you how continuous growing works.

24 **Try one new thing**
Add one plant you did not grow in Week 2. Choose something that complements what you already have. Do not overhaul the system — just extend it by one.

25 **Mulch or protect**
Add a thin layer of mulch around your plants to retain moisture and reduce weeds. Straw, wood chips, or even cardboard works. This saves you time watering later.

26 **Check your soil**
Push a finger into the soil around each plant. Is it staying too wet? Drying out too fast? Adjust your watering or add a thin layer of mulch. Good soil management prevents most problems before they start.

27 **Plan your next season**
Look ahead 2–3 months. What can you plant next? What would you like to try? Write a rough plan. Planning ahead is what separates a one-off attempt from a system.

28 **Cook with what you grew**
Make a meal or part of a meal using something from your garden. Even if it is just herbs in a salad. This closes the loop and reminds you why you started.

29 **Write your lessons**
What worked? What did you learn? What would you do differently? Write 3–5 bullet points. This is your growing knowledge building.

30 **Take your Day 30 photo**
Same angle as Day 14. Compare the two. You have been growing food for a month. That is not a project. That is the start of a system.

What comes next

You have done the hardest part. You started. The first 30 days are about proving to yourself that this works. Everything after that is just doing more of what you already know.

Your next steps

Keep your routine
The daily check-in is the single most important habit. Five minutes a day will teach you more than any amount of reading.

Expand slowly
Add one new crop per season. Do not redesign everything at once. Small additions compound over time.

Plan by season
Use your seasonal calendar to stay ahead. Knowing what to do next month prevents gaps and wasted effort.

Track what works
Write down what grew well, what did not, and what you would change. Review it before each new season.

> **REMEMBER**
> A home food system is not a project with an end date. It is a habit that compounds. Every season, you will know more, grow more, and waste less. That is the whole idea.

When you are ready to go deeper into food forest design, companion planting, perennial systems, and year-round growing, **The Complete Food Forest Guide** by Eva Greenleaf covers all of it.

Explore the book (affiliate link)

Thank you for using the 30-Day Food System Action Plan. Keep going.

Eva — Grow Food System